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The Richest Man in Babylon

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CHAPTER 1

The Man Who Desired Gold

The Man Who Desired Gold Bansir, the chariot builder of Babylon, was thoroughly discouraged. From his seat upon the low wall surrounding his property, he gazed sadly at his simple home and the open workshop in which stood a partially completed chariot. His wife frequently appeared at the open door. Her furtive glances in his direction reminded him that the meal bag was almost empty and he should be at work finishing the chariot, hammering and hewing, polishing and painting, stretching taut the leather over the wheel rims, preparing it for delivery so he could collect from his wealthy customer.

Nevertheless, his fat, muscular body sat stolidly upon the wall. His slow mind was struggling patiently with a problem for which he could find no answer. The hot, tropical sun, so typical of this valley of the Euphrates, beat down upon him mercilessly. Beads of perspiration formed upon his brow and trickled down unnoticed to lose themselves in the hairy jungle on his chest. 1 2
THERICHESTMAN INBABYLON Beyond his home towered the high terraced walls surrounding the king's palace.

Nearby, cleaving the blue heavens, was the painted tower of the Temple of Bel. In the shadow of such grandeur was his simple home and many others far less neat and well cared for. Babylon was like this—a mixture of grandeur and squalor, of dazzling wealth and

direst poverty, crowded together without plan or system within the protecting walls of the city. Behind him, had he cared to turn and look, the noisy chariots of the rich jostled and crowded aside the sandaled tradesmen as well as the barefooted beggars.

Even the rich were forced to turn into the gutters to clear the way for the long lines of slave water carriers, on the "king's business," each bearing a heavy goatskin of water to be poured upon the hanging gardens. Bansir was too engrossed in his own problem to hear or heed the confused hubbub of the busy city. It was the unexpected twanging of the strings from a familiar lyre that aroused him from his reverie.

He turned and looked into the sensitive, smiling face of his best friend—Kobbi, the musician. "May the Gods bless thee with great liberality, my good friend," began Kobbi with an elaborate salute. "Yet, it does appear they have already been so generous thou needest not to labour. I rejoice with thee in thy good fortune. More, I would even share it with thee. Pray, from thy purse which must be bulging else thou wouldst be busy in yon shop, extract but two humble shekels and lend them to me until after the noblemen's feast this night.

"Thou wilt not miss them ere they are returned." "If I did have two shekels," Bansir responded gloomily, "to no one could I lend them—not even to The Man Who Desired Gold 3 you, my best of friends; for they would be my fortune—my entire fortune. No one lends his entire fortune, not even to his best friend." "What,"

exclaimed Kobbi with genuine surprise. "Thou hast not one shekel in thy purse, yet sit like a statue upon a wall!

Why not complete that chariot? How else canst thou provide for thy noble appetite? 'Tis not like thee, my friend. Where is thy endless energy? Doth something distress thee? Have the Gods brought to thee troubles?" "A torment from the Gods it must be," Bansir agreed. "It began with a dream, a senseless dream, in which I thought I was a man of means. From my belt hung a handsome purse, heavy with coins.

There were shekels which I cast with careless freedom to the beggars; there were pieces of silver with which I did buy finery for my wife and whatever I did desire for myself; there were pieces of gold which made me feel assured of the future and unafraid to spend the silver. A glorious feeling of contentment was within me! You would not have known me for thy hardworking friend.

Nor wouldst have known my wife, so free from wrinkles was her face and shining with happiness. She was again the smiling maiden of our early married days." "A pleasant dream, indeed," commented Kobbi, "but why should such pleasant feelings as it aroused turn thee into a glum statue upon the wall?" "Why, indeed! Because when I awoke and remembered how empty was my purse, a feeling of rebellion swept over me.

Let us talk it over together, for, as the sailors do say, we ride in the same boat, we two. As youngsters, we went together to the priests to learn wisdom. As young men, we shared each other's

pleasures. As grown men, we have always been 4
THERICHESTMAN INBABYLON close friends. We have been
contented subjects of our kind. We have been satisfied to work long
hours and spend our earnings freely.

We have earned much coin in the years that have passed, yet to
know the joys that come from wealth, we must dream about them.
Bah! Are we more than dumb sheep? We live in the richest city in all
the world. The travellers do say none equals it in wealth. About us is
much display of wealth, but of it we ourselves have naught. After
half a lifetime of hard labour, thou, my best of friends, hast an empty
purse and sayest to me, 'May I borrow such a trifle as two shekels
until after the noblemen's feast this night?'

Then, what do I reply? Do I say, 'Here is my purse; its contents
will I gladly share?' No, I admit that my purse is as empty as thine.
What is the matter? Why cannot we acquire silver and gold—more
than enough for food and robes? "Consider, also, our sons," Bansir
continued, "are they not following in the footsteps of their fathers?
Need they and their families and their sons and their sons' families
live all their lives in the midst of such treasurers of gold, and yet,
like us, be content to banquet upon sour goat's milk and porridge?"

"Never, in all the years of our friendship, didst thou talk like this
before, Bansir." Kobbi was puzzled. "Never in all those years did I
think like this before. From early dawn until darkness stopped me, I
have laboured to build the finest chariots any man could make,
soft-heartedly hoping some day the Gods would recognize my

worthy deeds and bestow upon me great prosperity. This they have never done.

At last, I realize this they will never do. Therefore, my heart is sad. I wish to be a man of means. I wish The Man Who Desired Gold 5 to own lands and cattle, to have fine robes and coins in my purse. I am willing to work for these things with all the strength in my back, with all the skill in my hands, with all the cunning in my mind, but I wish my labours to be fairly rewarded.

What is the matter with us? Again I ask you! Why cannot we have our just share of the good things so plentiful for those who have the gold with which to buy them?" "Would I know an answer!" Kobbi replied. "No better than thou am I satisfied. My earnings from my lyre are quickly gone. Often must I plan and scheme that my family be not hungry. Also, within my breast is a deep longing for a lyre large enough that it may truly sing the strains of music that do surge through my mind.

With such an instrument could I make music finer than even the king has heard before?" "Such a lyre thou shouldst have. No man in all Babylon could make it sing more sweetly; could make it sing so sweetly, not only the king but the Gods themselves would be delighted. But how mayest thou secure it while we both of us are as poor as the king's slaves? Listen to the bell!

Here they come." He pointed to the long column of half-naked, sweating water bearers plodding labouriously up the narrow street from the river. Five abreast they marched, each bent under a heavy

goatskin of water. "A fine figure of a man, he who doth lead them." Kobbi indicated the wearer of the bell who marched in front without a load. "A prominent man in his own country, 'tis easy to see:" "There are many good figures in the line," Bansir agreed, "as good men as we.

Tall, blond men from the north, laughing black men from the south, little brown men from the nearer countries. All marching together from the river to the gardens, back and 6 THERICHESTMAN INBABYLON forth, day after day, year after year. Naught of happiness to look forward to. Beds of straw upon which to sleep—hard grain porridge to eat. Pity the poor brutes, Kobbi!" "Pity them I do. Yet, thou dost make me see how little better off are we, free men though we call ourselves."

"That is truth, Kobbi, unpleasant thought though it be. We do not wish to go on year after year living slavish lives. Working, working, working! Getting nowhere." "Might we not find out how others acquire gold and do as they do?" Kobbi inquired. "Perhaps there is some secret we might learn if we but sought from those who knew," replied Bansir thoughtfully. "This very day," suggested Kobbi, "I did pass our old friend, Arkad, riding in his golden chariot.

This I will say, he did not look over my humble head as many in his station might consider his right. Instead, he did wave his hand that all onlookers might see him pay greetings and bestow his smile of friendship upon Kobbi, the musician." "He is claimed to be the richest man in all Babylon," Bansir mused. "So rich the king is said

to seek his golden aid in affairs of the treasury," Kobbi replied.

"So rich," Bansir interrupted, "I fear if I should meet him in the darkness of the night, I should lay my hands upon his fat wallet." "Nonsense," reproved Kobbi, "a man's wealth is not in the purse he carries. A fat purse quickly empties if there be no golden stream to refill it. Arkad has an income that constantly keeps his purse full, no matter how liberally he spends." "Income, that is the thing," ejaculated Bansir.

"I The Man Who Desired Gold 7 wish an income that will keep flowing into my purse whether I sit upon the wall or travel to far lands. Arkad must know how a man can make an income for himself. Dost suppose it is something he could make clear to a mind as slow as mine?" "Methinks he did teach his knowledge to his son, Nomasir," Kobbi responded. "Did he not go to Nineveh and, so it is told at the inn, become, without aid from his father, one of the richest men in that city?"

"Kobbi, thou bringest to me a rare thought." A new light gleamed in Bansir's eyes. "It costs nothing to ask wise advice from a good friend and Arkad was always that. Never mind though our purses be as empty as the falcon's nest of a year ago. Let that not detain us. We are weary of being without gold in the midst of plenty. We wish to become men of means.

Come, let us go to Arkad and ask how we, also, may acquire incomes for ourselves." "Thou speakest with true inspiration, Bansir. Thou bringest to my mind a new understanding. Thou makest me to

realize the reason why we have never found any measure of wealth. We never sought it. Thou hast laboured patiently to build the staunchest chariots in Babylon. To that purpose was devoted your best endeavours. Therefore, at it thou didst succeed.

I strove to become a skilful lyre player. And, at it I did succeed. "In those things toward which we exerted our best endeavours we succeeded. The Gods were content to let us continue thus. Now, at last, we see a light, bright like that from the rising sun. It biddeth us to learn more that we may prosper more. With a new understanding we shall find honourable ways to accomplish our desires."

8 THERICHESTMAN INBABYLON "Let us go to Arkad this very day," Bansir urged. "Also, let us ask other friends of our boyhood days, . who have fared no better than ourselves, to join us that they, too, may share in his wisdom." "Thou wert ever thus thoughtful of thy friends, Bansir. Therefore hast thou many friends. It shall be as thou sayest. We go this day and take them with us."

The Richest Man in Babylon In old Babylon there once lived a certain very rich man named Arkad. Far and wide he was famed for his great wealth. Also was he famed for his liberality. He was generous in his charities. He was generous with his family. He was liberal in his own expenses. But nevertheless each year his wealth increased more rapidly than he spent it. And there were certain friends of younger days who came to him and said: "You, Arkad, are more fortunate than we.

You have become the richest man in all Babylon while we struggle for existence. You can wear the finest garments and you can enjoy the rarest foods, while we must be content if we can clothe our families in raiment that is presentable and feed them as best we can. "Yet, once we were equal. We studied under the same master. We played in the same games. And in neither the studies nor the games did you outshine us.

And in the years since, you have been no more an honourable citizen than we. 9 10 THE RICHEST MAN IN BABYLON "Nor have you worked harder or more faithfully, insofar as we can judge. Why, then, should a fickle fate single you out to enjoy all the good things of life and ignore us who are equally deserving?" Thereupon Arkad remonstrated with them, saying, "If you have not acquired more than a bare existence in the years since we were youths, it is because you either have failed to learn the laws that govern the building of wealth, or else you do not observe them.

" 'Fickle Fate' is a vicious goddess who brings no permanent good to anyone. On the contrary, she brings ruin to almost every man upon whom she showers unearned gold. She makes wanton spenders, who soon dissipate all they receive and are left beset by overwhelming appetites and desires they have not the ability to gratify. Yet others whom she favours become misers and hoard their wealth, fearing to spend what they have, knowing they do not possess the ability to replace it.

They further are beset by fear of robbers and doom themselves to lives of emptiness and secret misery. "Others there probably are, who can take unearned gold and add to it and continue to be happy and contented citizens. But so few are they, I know of them but by hearsay. Think you of the men who have inherited sudden wealth, and see if these things are not so." His friends admitted that of the men they knew who had inherited wealth these words were true, and they besought him to explain to them how he had become possessed of so much prosperity, so he continued: "In my youth I looked about me and saw all the good things there were to bring happiness and con-

The Richest Man in

Babylon tentment. And I realized that wealth increased the potency of all these. "Wealth is a power. With wealth many things are possible. "One may ornament the home with the richest of furnishings. "One may sail the distant seas. "One may feast on the delicacies of far lands. "One may buy the ornaments of the gold worker and the stone polisher. "One may even build mighty temples for the Gods.

"One may do all these things and many others in which there is delight for the senses and gratification for the soul. "And, when I realized all this, I decided to myself that I would claim my share of the good things of life. I would not be one of those who stand afar off, enviously watching others enjoy. I would not be con- . tent to clothe myself in the cheapest raiment that looked respectable.

I would not be satisfied-with the lot of a poor man. On the contrary, I would make myself a guest at this banquet of good things. "Being, as you know, the son of a humble merchant, one of a large family with no hope of an inheritance, and not being endowed, as you have so frankly said, with superior powers or wisdom, I decided that if I was to achieve what I desired, time and study would be required.

"As for time, all men have it in abundance. You, each of you, have let slip by sufficient time to have made yourselves wealthy. Yet, you admit, you have nothing to show except your good families, of which you can be justly proud. "As for study, did not our wise teacher teach us 12 THE RICHEST MAN IN BABYLON that learning was of two kinds: the one kind being the things we learned and knew, and the other being the training that taught us how to find out what we did not know?

"Therefore did I decide to find out how one might accumulate wealth, and when I had found out, to make this my task and do it well. For," is it not wise that we should enjoy while we dwell in the brightness of the sunshine, for sorrows enough shall descend upon us when we depart for the darkness of the world of spirit? "I found employment as a scribe in the hall of records, and long hours each day I laboured upon the clay tablets.

Week after week, and month after month, I laboured, yet for my earnings I had naught to show. Food and clothing and penance to the Gods, and other things of which I could remember not what,

absorbed all my earnings. But my determination did not leave me. "And one day Algamish, the money lender, came to the house of the city master and ordered a copy of the Ninth Law, and he said to me, 'I must have this in two days, and if the task is done by that time, two coppers will I give to thee.'

"So I laboured hard, but the law was long, and when Algamish returned the task was unfinished. He was angry, and had I been his slave, he would have beaten me. But knowing the city master would not permit him to injure me, I was unafraid, so I said to him, 'Algamish, you are a very rich man. Tell me how I may also become rich, and all night I will carve upon the clay, and when the sun rises it shall be completed.'

'He smiled at me and replied, 'You are a forward knave, but we will call it a bargain.' The Richest Man in Babylon 13 "All that night I carved, though my back pained and the smell of the wick made my head ache until my eyes could hardly see. But when he returned at sunup, the tablets were complete. " 'Now' I said, 'tell me what you promised.' " 'You have fulfilled your part of our bargain, my son,' he said to me kindly, 'and I am ready to fulfil mine, I will tell you these things you wish to know because I am becoming an old man, and an old tongue loves to wag.

And when youth comes to age for advice he receives the wisdom of years. But too often does youth think that age knows only the wisdom of days that are gone, and therefore profits not. But remember this, the sun that shines today is the sun that shone when

thy father was born, and will still be shining when thy last grandchild shall pass into the darkness. " 'The thoughts of youth,' he continued, 'are bright lights that shine forth like the meteors that oft make brilliant the sky, but the wisdom of age is like the fixed stars that shine so unchanged that the sailor may depend upon them to steer his course.

" 'Mark you well my words, for if you do not you will fail to grasp the truth that I will tell you, and you will think that your night's work has been in vain.' "Then he looked at me shrewdly from under his shaggy brows and said in a low, forceful tone, 'I found the road to wealth when I decided that a part of all I earned was mine to keep. And so will you.'

"Then he continued to look at me with a glance that I could feel pierce me but said no more. " 'Is that all?' I asked. " 'That was sufficient to change the heart of a sheep herder into the heart of a money lender,' he replied. 14 THE RICHEST MAN IN BABYLON "But all I earn is mine to keep, is it not?' I demanded. "Far from it,' he replied. 'Do you not pay the garment-maker?

Do you not pay the sandal-maker? Do you not pay for the things you eat? Can you live in Babylon without spending? What have you to show for your earnings of the past month? What for the past year? Fool! You pay to everyone but yourself. Dullard, you labour for others. As well be a slave and work for what your master gives you to eat and wear. If you did keep for yourself one-tenth of all you earn, how much would you have in ten years?'

"My knowledge of the numbers did not forsake me, and I answered, 'As much as I earn in one year.' " 'You speak but half the truth' he retorted. 'Every gold piece you save is a slave to work for you. Every copper it earns is its child that also can earn for you. If you would become wealthy, then what you save must earn, and its children must earn, that all may help to give to you the abundance you crave.

" 'You think I cheat you for your long night's work,' he continued,' but I am paying you a thousand times over if you have the intelligence to grasp the truth I offer you. " 'A part of all you earn is yours to keep. It should be not less than a tenth no matter how little you earn. It can be as much more as you can afford. Pay yourself first.

Do not buy from the clothes-maker and the sandal-maker more than you can pay out of the rest and still have enough for food and charity and penance to the Gods. " 'Wealth, like a tree, grows from a tiny seed. The first copper you save is the seed from which your tree of wealth shall grow. The sooner you plant that seed the sooner shall the tree grow. And the more The Richest Man in Babylon 15 faithfully you nourish and water that tree with consistent savings, the sooner may you bask in contentment beneath its shade.'

"So saying, he took his tablets and went away. "I thought much about what he had said to me, and it seemed reasonable. So I decided that I would try it. Each time I was paid I took one from each ten pieces of copper and hid it away. And strange as it may seem, I was

no shorter of funds than before. I noticed little difference as I managed to get along without it.

But often I was tempted, as my hoard began to grow, to spend it for some of the good things the merchants displayed, brought by camels and ships from the land of the Phoenicians. But I wisely refrained. "A twelfth month after Algamish had gone he again returned and said to me, 'Son, have you paid to yourself not less than one-tenth of all you have earned for the past year?'

"I answered proudly, 'Yes, master, I have.' " "That is good/ he answered beaming upon me, 'and what have you done with it?' " "I have given it to Azmur, the brick maker, who told me he was travelling over the far seas and in Tyre he would buy for me the rare jewels of the Phoenicians. When he returns we shall sell these at high prices and divide the earnings.'

" 'Every fool must learn,' he growled, 'but why trust the knowledge of a brick maker about jewels? Would you go to the bread maker to inquire about the stars? No, by my tunic, you would go to the astrologer, if you had power to think. Your savings are gone, youth; you have jerked your wealth-tree up by the roots. But plant another. Try again. And next time if you would have advice about jewels, go 16 THERICHESTMAN INBABYLON to the jewel merchant.

If you would know the truth about sheep, go to the herdsman. Advice is one thing that is freely given away, but watch that you take only what is worth having. He who takes advice about his

savings from one who is inexperienced in such matters, shall pay with his savings for .proving the falsity of their opinions.' Saying this, he went away. "And it was as he said. For the Phoenicians are scoundrels and sold to Azmur worthless bits of glass that looked like gems.

But as Algamish had bid me, I again saved each tenth copper, for I now had formed the habit and it was no longer difficult. "Again, twelve months later, Algamish came to the room of the scribes and addressed me. 'What progress have you made since last I saw you?' " 'I have paid myself faithfully/ I replied, 'and my savings I have entrusted to Aggar the shield maker, to buy bronze, and each fourth month he does pay me the rental.'

"That is good. And what do you do with the rental?' " 'I do have a great feast with honey and fine wine and spiced cake. Also I have bought me a scarlet tunic. And some day I shall buy me a young ass upon which to ride.' "To which Algamish laughed, 'You do eat the children of your savings. Then how do you expect them to work for you?

And how can they have children that will also work for you? First get thee an army of golden slaves and then many a rich banquet may you enjoy without regret/ So saying he again went away. "Nor did I again see him for two years, when he once more returned and his face was full of deep The Richest Man in Babylon .17 lines and his eyes drooped, for he was becoming a very old man And he said to me, 'Arkad, hast thou yet achieved the wealth thou dreamed of?'

"And I answered, 'Not yet all that I desire, but some I have and it earns more, and its earnings earn more' " 'And do you still take the advice of brick makers?' " 'About brick making they give good advice,' I retorted. "'Arkad,' he continued, 'you have learned your lessons well. You first learned to live upon less than you could earn. Next you learned to seek advice from those who were competent through their own experiences to give it.

And, lastly, you have learned to make gold work for you. " 'You have taught yourself how to acquire money, how to keep it and how to use it. Therefore, you are competent for a responsible position.' I am becoming an old man. My sons think only of spending and give no thought to earning. My interests are great and I fear too much for me to look after. If you will go to Nippur and look after my lands there, I shall make you my partner and you shall share in my estate.'

"So I went to Nippur and took charge of his holdings, which were large. And because I was full of ambition and because I had mastered the three laws of successfully handling wealth, I was enabled to increase greatly the value of his properties. So I prospered much, and when the spirit of Algamish departed for the sphere of darkness, I did share in his estate as he had arranged under the law."

So spake Arkad, and when he had finished his tale, one of his friends said, "You were indeed fortunate that Algamish made of you an heir." 18 THE RICHEST MAN IN BABYLON "Fortunate only in that I had the desire to prosper before I first met him. For four years did I not prove my definiteness of purpose by keeping one-tenth of

all I earned? Would you call a fisherman lucky who for years so studied the habits of the fish that with each changing wind he could cast his nets about them?

Opportunity is a haughty goddess who wastes no time with those who are unprepared." "You had strong willpower to keep on after you lost your first year's savings. You are unusual in that way," spoke up another. "Willpower!" retorted Arkad. "What nonsense. Do you think willpower gives a man the strength to lift a burden the camel cannot carry, or to draw a load the oxen cannot budge? Will power is but the unflinching purpose to carry a task you set for yourself to fulfilment.

If I set for myself a task, be it ever so trifling, I shall see it through. How else shall I have confidence in myself to do important things? Should I say to myself, 'For a hundred days as I walk across the bridge into the city, I will pick from the road a pebble and cast it into the stream/ I would do it If on the seventh day I passed by without remembering, I would not say to myself, 'Tomorrow I will cast two pebbles which will do as well/ Instead, I would retrace my steps and cast the pebble.

Nor on the twentieth day would I say to myself, 'Arkad, this is useless. What does it avail you to cast a pebble every day? Throw in a handful and be done with it.' No, I would not say that nor do it. When I set a task for myself, I complete it. Therefore, I am careful not to start difficult and impractical tasks, because I love leisure." And then another friend spoke up and said, "If what you tell is true,

and it does seem as you have